OPEN SPOT

BOOK A SPOT.
~~NOT A COURT.~~

A platform that matches New Yorkers by sport, level and time into games on courts already booked.

Team 8: Alara, Kobe, Obiari, Lingkai, Yunji · HCDIx Design Document · 2026

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Matches New Yorkers by sport, level and time into games on courts already booked.

6:30 PM	**Central Park** Doubles · NTRP 3.5	**$15/spot** 1 spot left
7:30 PM	**McCarren Park** Doubles · NTRP 3.0	**$12/spot** 1 spot left
7:00 AM	**Prospect Park** Doubles · NTRP 3.5	**$30/spot** 2 spots left

1 **Say what you play.** Sport, level, borough, time.

2 **Take a spot** on a court that is already booked.

3 **Pay your share.** $60 court ÷ 4 = $15 each.

4 **Play.** The waitlist fills any dropout.

THE NEED

4 of 5
interviewees had no one to play with.

WHY IT WINS

Finds the people
Backfills dropouts
Splits fees for you

WHAT'S NEXT

Play again
No-show prediction
Venue and city tools

"I just drop into a game at my level." Tennis player, concept test

Alara, Kobe, Obiari, Lingkai, Yunji · A small fee per spot

New Yorkers in their 20s and 30s who want a game

PRIMARY USER

The solo newcomer

Recently arrived, owns the gear, knows no one to play with. Seeking same-day, level-matched network to play with.

Matthew: moved from Boston, played once in 2 months.

PRIMARY USER

The game organizer

Holds court bookings, but deals with dropouts and payment chasing. Wants full headcount and upfront payment.

Priya: runs a weekly basketball group, played 4 times in 10 months.

Other key stakeholders, and what Open Spot offers them

Private clubs and venues:
Protects revenue by filling spots and last-minute cancellations.

NYC Parks:
Maximizes public court utilization while staying within permit rules.

Waitlisted players:
Provides fair, automated access to game openings.

People and planning keep New Yorkers off the court

5 of 5	**wanted to play,** yet scheduling failures stopped them or disrupted their plans	*“I’m not downloading 2–3 different apps just to play tennis.”* *Jadon, frustrated local*
4 of 5	**had no one to play with.** A free court alone would not have be sufficient for them	*“I want to learn and meet people through tennis, but I don’t even know where to start.” Sue, newcomer in NY*
4 games	**in 10 months** for an organizer. Dropouts wear down the groups that do exist.	*“Half the group drops out before I find one.”* *Priya, on finding a gym*
10,000+	**open matches in the US in 2025** on Playtomic. People will play with strangers.	*“Open Spot is how I might actually meet partners.”* *Solo pickleball player, prototype testing*

People want to play but can’t get a game together

New Yorkers in their 20s and 30s want to play, but finding partners, managing dropouts, and chasing payments stops them before they reach the court.

No group

4 of 5 interviewees lack local game partners, leaving gear unused at home.

Scarce Court

NYC court capacity sits 98% below the national average, making half-empty games a waste of scarce space.

Rigid Rules

$15 permits and 7-day advance limits block same-day online booking, stopping spontaneous play.

From “I want to play” to a game in minutes

Morning

A newcomer opens Open Spot to find a game tonight.

Then

Claims the last spot in a 3.5 doubles match for $15.

2 hours out

Receives automated confirmation as the match fills.

Late cancel

A player cancels; the waitlist auto-fills the spot.

Game time

Four matched players play. Tap "Play again" for next week

Player feels

"I found a level-matched game and new partners instantly."

Organizer feels

"I listed open spots, skipped the admin, and just played."

Venue feels

"Maximum court capacity with zero wasted slots."

How a booked court becomes a full game

1

Match

Choose sport, level, borough and time. See only games within half a level of yours.

2

Take a spot

Join a court that is already booked. No permit search, no group needed.

3

Split

$60 court ÷ 4 players = $15 each. Settled automatically at check-in.

4

Play

Confirmed two hours out. The waitlist fills dropouts, and alerts flag open spots.

Where courts come from

Organizers post open spots first. Partner venues follow.

How it makes money

A small fee on each spot filled, on top of the court share.

How it grows

One sport in one neighborhood, then only where games fill.

Open Spot connects booked courts to open players

Court supply

Organizers' bookings
Private clubs and venues
NYC Parks courts

open spots →
← court fees

OPEN SPOT

Matching · waitlist
fee split · alerts

games →
← spot + fee

Players

Solo newcomers
Spontaneous regulars
Waitlisted players

Runs on: payments · NTRP and DUPR ratings · phone alerts · venue and NYC Parks rules

How court access expands

Now: organizers post open spots on courts they booked.

Next: partner venues release slots that would sit half-empty.

Later: a tool for the city to fill its pre-booked courts.

How Open Spot compares to the alternatives

	Open Spot	Playtomic	Plei	Pickleheads	Volo
Sports	Racket first, then team sports	Padel, pickleball, tennis	Soccer only	Pickleball only	Many, by league
You commit to	One spot in one game	A court or an open match	One pickup game	One open-play session	A full season
Level match	NTRP or DUPR band per game	Its own level estimate	Not listed	Self-rated	League divisions
Dropouts	Waitlist backfills, two hours out	Organizer replaces	Not listed	Not listed	Not listed
Payment	Auto-split at check-in	Booker pays, or players split	Pay for your spot	Not listed	League fee

Proof of demand:
Playtomic reports 4M users and 6,700+ clubs, and more than 20% of its UK bookings are open matches.

Elevator pitch

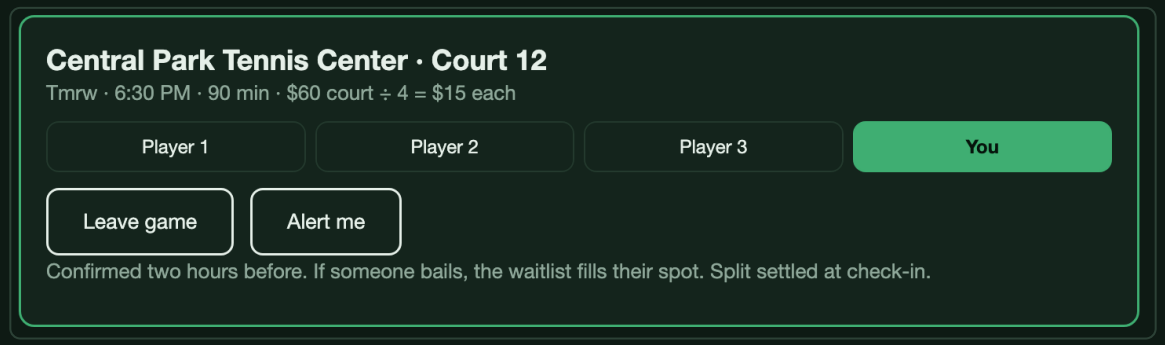
New Yorkers in their 20s and 30s, especially recent arrivals, are eager to play sports but struggle to organize sports games. People wanted to play, but recurring hurdles- finding teammates, last-minute dropouts, and payment headaches- forced them to play less or give up entirely.

On the other hand, apps like Playtomic and Plei have shown that players will join games with strangers.

We have created a platform that matches players by sport, level and time into games on courts already booked. Players find a game, organizers fill every spot - we just take a small fee per spot.

A working prototype that testers ranked first





What testers said

2 of 3 ranked it first among the concepts tested; none ranked it last.

“I don’t need a pre-existing group or court. I just drop into a game at my level.”

Built from feedback

Singles and hitting sessions, plus alerts for spots opening in the next three hours.

Next refinements

“Play again” with favorite players, standing weekly games and a map of games.

Future technology

No-show prediction, DUPR and NTRP rating import and live venue booking links.